PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #57 · PTSD

“Other people can see that I am different now, and they will keep their distance.”

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Where it often comes from

Being hurt can change how you carry yourself. You may feel marked, odd, or easy to spot. Sometimes people really have been clumsy or distant. The lie says they can see that you are different and therefore they will keep away, as if your wound were a sign on your face. Most people cannot read your history. Some who know it can stay. You do not have to explain what happened in order to test this. A counselor can help you sort fear from fact. A counselor can help you work with this at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do it alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

The Lord is near the brokenhearted. He does not keep His distance from wounds. Nothing can separate you from the love of God in Christ. Grace is sufficient when you feel exposed. God binds up the brokenhearted rather than stepping back from them. Jesus says not to let your heart be troubled. People are limited and sometimes unkind. Their distance, real or imagined, is not God’s posture toward you, and it is not a law that everyone will leave.

> *“The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit”* (Psalm 34:18).

Also see

> “For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord” (Romans 8:38–39).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners” (Isaiah 61:1).

> “Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you. I do not give to you as the world gives. Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid” (John 14:27).

Common self-statements

- They can tell.
- If they knew, they would step back.
- I should stay away so I do not make people uncomfortable.
- I am too different to belong.
- Looking fine is the only way to be tolerated.
- God is probably keeping His distance too.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Deciding you know that people see your past and will leave.
- Overgeneralization: Turning one awkward reaction into “everyone will keep away.”
- Labeling: Calling yourself too different to belong.

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling exposed and concluding that you are exposed to everyone.

Challenging questions

- What do people actually see, and what am I sure they know?
- Who has come closer instead of stepping back?
- Do I pull away first and then call it their distance?
- Would I avoid a friend who had been hurt?
- What does God do with the brokenhearted?
- What would letting one safe person stay look like, without telling more than I want?

Truth summary

> Some people may notice I am struggling, and that does not mean everyone will keep their distance. God is near, and safe people can stay.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Loneliness
- Friendship
- Love, By God
- Thinking, Healthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Love
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
You can be honest about being changed without deciding everyone is backing away.

If We Are the Body — Casting Crowns
The people of God are called to come near, not to keep their distance.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
God's love, not other people's stare, is what names you.

Jesus Loves Me — Gaither Vocal Band
Jesus loves you as you are, including the ways you have been changed.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "Other people can see that I am different now, and they will keep their distance."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Other people can see that I am different now, and they will keep their distance." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do people actually see, and what am I sure they know?
- ☐ Who has come closer instead of stepping back?
- ☐ Do I pull away first and then call it their distance?
- ☐ Would I avoid a friend who had been hurt?
- ☐ What does God do with the brokenhearted?
- ☐ What would letting one safe person stay look like, without telling more than I want?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Some people may notice I am struggling, and that does not mean everyone will keep their distance. God is near, and safe people can stay.
- ☐ My history is not written on my face.
- ☐ God draws near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ One person's distance is not everyone's.
- ☐ I can be changed and still be lovable.
- ☐ I do not owe anyone the story.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Romans 8:38–39
  "For I am convinced that neither death nor life, neither angels nor principalities, neither the present nor the future, nor any powers, neither height nor depth, nor anything else in all creation, will be able to separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord."

☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9

"But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you felt too different to be near: Each day, write down one moment when you were sure people would step back. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 34:18 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is near the brokenhearted. I do not have to hide to be met.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Loneliness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Test one interaction. Have one ordinary conversation without explaining your history. Write whether the person actually withdrew.
- [ ] Ask your counselor what is fear and what is a real pattern of people leaving. Do not decide alone.
- [ ] Let one safe person know you are having a hard day without telling the story. Notice if they stay.
- [ ] Read Psalm 34:18 when you want to disappear from a room.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Other people can see that I am different now, and they will keep their distance.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A person who did not step back
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Other people can see that I am different now, and they will keep their distance~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I feel marked and sure that people will back away. You draw near to the brokenhearted. Help me not to hide from every person, and help me trust the ones who are safe. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.